Community-Based Voluntary Elderly Care Services: From Fragmentation to Integration, A Case Study of Three Community Centers in N City, China

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Abstract

In contemporary China, community-based elderly care has become a central strategy for responding to population aging. Voluntary services constitute an indispensable component of this model, yet their effectiveness remains uneven. Drawing on semi-structured interviews with community service staff and survey data from elderly residents, this study examines the structural problems affecting voluntary participation in community elderly care services. The findings reveal pronounced fragmentation across service teams, motivations, time allocation, and service content. This fragmentation stems from institutional disparities among community centers, deficiencies in volunteer management and training, and the absence of unified evaluation mechanisms. The article argues that improving community voluntary elderly care requires systemic integration through team stabilization, capacity building, and coordinated institutional support.

Keywords: community elderly care; voluntary services; fragmentation; service integration

1. Background

Population aging has become one of the most significant demographic challenges facing contemporary China. In response, community-based elderly care has emerged as a key policy orientation, aiming to provide localized, accessible, and diversified services for older adults.[1] Most urban communities have established elderly service centers staffed by professionals who deliver direct services or mobilize social resources to meet the daily needs of elderly residents.

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[1] Chen Youhua, *Population Aging and Elderly Care in Contemporary China* (Beijing: Social Sciences Academic Press, 2013); Wang Yuesheng, "Community Elderly Care Service Systems under Population Aging," *Journal of Public Administration* 11, no. 1 (2014): 67–78.

Alongside formal care provision, volunteer-based elderly care services have developed rapidly and are now regarded as an essential supplement to institutional and family care.[2]

Despite their growing presence, voluntary elderly care services frequently encounter problems related to unstable participation, limited professionalism, and discontinuous service delivery. These issues undermine service sustainability and effectiveness, making the improvement of community-based voluntary elderly care an urgent empirical and policy concern.[3]

2. Literature Review

Existing research widely acknowledges the importance of voluntary service in community elderly care systems. Studies show that volunteers are primarily drawn from university students, community residents, and the "young-old," and that services typically focus on daily assistance and emotional support.[4] At the same time, scholars have identified persistent problems such as insufficient volunteer numbers, imbalanced volunteer structures, weak organizational capacity, and the lack of standardized operational mechanisms.[5]

In response, various studies propose strengthening community volunteer platforms, enhancing team construction, innovating service content, and improving management systems.[6] While these contributions offer valuable insights, they often address surface-level organizational issues without identifying a deeper structural problem—namely, **fragmentation**. Fragmentation manifests in discontinuous services, weak coordination, and low overall effectiveness, and has been shown in other social domains to significantly reduce performance and sustainability.[7]

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[2] Du Peng and Wang Junxiu, "Community-Based Elderly Care Services in Urban China," *Population Research* 39, no. 4 (2015): 3–14.

[3] Ministry of Civil Affairs of the People's Republic of China, *Guiding Opinions on Promoting the Development of Community-Based Elderly Care Services* (Beijing, 2017).

[4] Xu Anqi, "Volunteerism and Social Support for the Elderly in Urban China," *Chinese Journal of Sociology* 36, no. 5 (2016): 112–129.

[5] Li Jianxin and Li Yu, "Volunteer Participation in Community Elderly Care," *Chinese Journal of Gerontology* 38, no. 12 (2018): 3021–3024.

[6] Zhang Kaining and Zhou Xiaohong, "From Fragmentation to Coordination," *Journal of Social Policy* 22, no. 4 (2019): 54–66.

[7] Liu Hongyu, "Fragmentation and Integration in Social Service Provision," *Social Sciences in China* 40, no. 3 (2019): 82–99.

Applying this analytical framework to community voluntary elderly care reveals fragmentation as a fundamental obstacle to service improvement.[8]

3. Methodology

This study adopts a mixed qualitative–quantitative research design.

3.1 Interviews

Semi-structured interviews were conducted with nine staff members from three community elderly care centers (Communities A, B, and C) in N City. Interviewees included directors of residents ’committees, elderly care coordinators, and center managers. Prior to the interviews, participants were provided with a clear explanation of the concept of fragmentation. They were then asked three core questions: whether fragmentation exists in voluntary elderly care services, how it manifests, and what factors contribute to it.

3.2 Survey of Elderly Residents

To triangulate interview data, a random survey was conducted with sixty elderly residents (twenty from each community) who regularly received services from the same centers. After clarifying the meaning of fragmentation, respondents were asked whether they perceived fragmentation in services and in what forms.

4. Findings

4.1 Prevalence of Fragmentation

Eight of the nine staff members (89 percent) and fifty-three of the sixty elderly respondents (88.3 percent) confirmed the existence of fragmentation in community voluntary elderly care services, indicating that fragmentation is both widespread and perceptible.

4.2 Dimensions of Fragmentation

4.2.1 Fragmentation of Service Teams

Service teams are characterized by instability and weak organization. Volunteer attendance is irregular, service schedules are unpredictable, and participation often occurs without coordination. Volunteers are predominantly primary and secondary school students, while adult

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[8] He Xuefeng, “From Administrative Fragmentation to Social Integration,” *Journal of China Agricultural University (Social Sciences Edition)* 31, no. 2 (2014): 5–14.

community residents—especially working-age individuals—are largely absent. This imbalance undermines continuity and service quality.[9]

4.2.2 Fragmentation of Service Motivation

Volunteer motivations are frequently instrumental rather than service-oriented. Student volunteers often participate to fulfill school requirements, resulting in passive or perfunctory engagement. Genuine commitment to long-term elderly care remains limited.[10]

4.2.3 Fragmentation of Service Time

Volunteer services are concentrated around symbolic dates or festivals, such as "Learn from Lei Feng Day" or traditional holidays. Outside these periods, sustained and regular services are rare. Elderly respondents reported limited and irregular access to volunteer assistance.[11]

4.2.4 Fragmentation of Service Content

Service content is largely confined to short-term, low-skill activities such as nail trimming, cleaning, storytelling, and performances. Long-term needs—including continuous life care, health monitoring, and sustained emotional support—are insufficiently addressed.[12]

5. Causes of Fragmentation

5.1 Institutional Factors

Differences in geographic location, organizational scale, and institutional reputation affect access to volunteer resources. Community centers located near schools or with better infrastructure attract more volunteers. Moreover, variation in organizational initiative plays a crucial role.

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[9] He, "From Administrative Fragmentation to Social Integration," 6.

[10] Xu, "Volunteerism and Social Support," 120–124.

[11] Sun Tangshui, "Problems and Countermeasures of Community Volunteer Elderly Care Services," *Journal of Social Work* 10, no. 6 (2020): 45–52.

[12] Li and Li, "Volunteer Participation in Community Elderly Care," 3023–3024.

Communities that actively establish partnerships with schools and implement structured volunteer management models achieve higher service frequency and stability.[13]

5.2 Volunteer-Related Factors

Many volunteers lack a clear understanding of elderly care as a sustained social responsibility. In addition, insufficient training in geriatric health, psychology, and communication skills leads to discomfort and ineffective service delivery, further discouraging long-term participation.[14]

5.3 Structural Factors

A lack of unified organizational coordination results in scheduling conflicts and operational disorder. At the same time, weak evaluation and incentive mechanisms limit accountability and quality control. Despite dissatisfaction, service centers often continue to accept poorly performing volunteers due to chronic labor shortages.[15]

6. Strategies for Integration

Addressing fragmentation requires systemic integration rather than isolated interventions. First, community volunteer resources should be consolidated to form stable service teams with defined volunteer–elderly ratios. Second, professional training programs should be introduced to enhance volunteer capacity in elderly care knowledge and skills. Finally, governments should establish coordinated institutional mechanisms involving communities, schools, and social organizations, supported by standardized evaluation and incentive systems.[16]

Conclusion

This study demonstrates that fragmentation constitutes a fundamental obstacle to the effectiveness of community-based voluntary elderly care services in China. Improving service outcomes requires not only expanding volunteer participation but also integrating organizational structures, professional capacities, and institutional support systems. Through coordinated

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[13] Zhang and Zhou, “From Fragmentation to Coordination,” 60–64.

[14] Xu, “Volunteerism and Social Support,” 118–121.

[15] Liu, “Fragmentation and Integration,” 90–95.

[16] Ministry of Civil Affairs, *Guiding Opinions*, 5–9.

governance and sustained investment, community voluntary elderly care services can achieve greater stability, quality, and social impact.[17]

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[17] Sun, "Problems and Countermeasures," 50–52.